

Namecoin blockchain to enable the creation of and access to websites that have a Namecoin identity.

Namecoin acts as its own DNS service, and provides users with more control and privacy. As opposed to the typical way in which websites are registered through a government controlled service such as ICANN, a Namecoin site is registered through a service that exists on each computer on the Namecoin network. This improves security, privacy, and speed. To gain a .bit site, one must have namecoin to do so, thus the need for the native asset.

Litecoin

While a handful of altcoins were released through 2011, Litecoin was the first that would retain significant value to this day. The cryptocurrency was developed by Charlie Lee, an MIT graduate who was a software engineer at Google. When Lee learned of Bitcoin he quickly understood its power, leading him to mine bitcoin before trying to create his own variants. After the unsuccessful launch of Fairbrix in September 2011, Lee tried again with Litecoin in October.¹⁸

Litecoin aimed to improve upon Bitcoin in two ways. For one, Litecoin's block times were 2.5 minutes, four times faster than Bitcoin's, which would be important for merchants needing faster confirmation of consumer's payments.

Second, Litecoin used a different hash function in the proof-of-work process—also known as a block hashing algorithm—which tried to make the mining process more accessible to hobbyists. To put it into perspective, in the early